

*[This letter dated **August 8, 1926** was written from Kuliang by Willard Beard to daughter, Kathleen. He mentions Kathleen's upcoming 18th birthday and congratulates her on her acceptance to Oberlin College. He mentions the new taxes levied, the weather, new foreign items found in the shops, a tennis tournament in Kuliang, and the murder of a Foochow Chamber of Commerce vice chairman. He includes a note to Geraldine advising her on what to do with the money in the bank account of her now deceased sister, Phebe. Letter is in Jill Jackson's collection.]*

#316 Kuliang
Foochow, China
Sunday, August 8th 1926

Dear Kathleen,

I am thinking of a day eighteen years ago here on Kuliang, actually eighteen years ago day after tomorrow when a wee girlie came to our home. How the days and weeks and months and years have sped by! That wee bit of humanity is a member of the freshman class 1926-7 of Oberlin College. I've already sent my congratulations to you for the good standing in your High School work last term, and here are congratulations for the acceptance into the freshman class and best wishes for a successful year in College.

I am glad that Marjorie and you can be together in a College house this year and I hope you will get out of it all that you anticipate. It will be the first year you have been in school with no mom or older sister but what of that? I suppose very few girls or boys in College have parents or older sisters or brothers with them.

It is 11:15 a.m. I am on our veranda with most of Kuliang spread out before me, and farther off the plain, and then the city of Foochow, and then the river- mostly yellow sand now, for no rain has fallen since July 3 - then the mountains. This morning they lie in a sort of haze. Clouds obscure the sun. It is very still and close and hot- they say it is very hot in Foochow. The dry weather is raising prices of all food. As if this were not enough to give poor people heavy burdens, the military are heaping all manner of taxes on them for everything. Merchants and farmers and ricksha men and boatmen and craftsmen – all have to bear it, until they- whole families are moving to the Straights Settlements- perhaps 2000 have gone from Fukien during the past 18 months. I do not see how, when or where this condition is to end. With it all people seem to have money as they did not in earlier years. The stores in Foochow are full of foreign style, hats, shoes, raincoats, cloth and watches, clocks, hot water bottles, flashlights, glasses, medicines, cakes, tinned goods, etc, etc. Horses and carriages and autos are on the streets continually. The only conveyances you ever saw here were sedans. A week ago today the vice chairman of the Chinese Foochow

Chamber of Commerce was invited to a temple a little way out from the city and his body riddled with bullets. He has been helping military governor Ciu levy taxes on the merchants. But this is enough of the dark side. On the other side the work of church and Christian school goes on successfully. Over 100 teachers- men and women have been studying in Foochow for the past six weeks to better fit themselves to teach. The weather has been hot, the schedule heavy but they have stuck to it- the leaders also- mostly Chinese, giving their services. The churches are doing better work this year than for several years. The people in general were never more ready to hear and accept the story of Jesus and of his salvation. The Chinese are more and more taking responsibilities.

I will send the Kuliang registers home soon. You children may like to glance at them, and then send them to Aunt Mary. She will read them with the most recent knowledge of Kuliang of anyone at home. This summer the tennis courts and the bathing pool are very popular. The Sunday evening sings do not draw as many people this year. No new houses are going up. About a dozen are for sale. I wonder when ours will be for sale. Do you remember Elizabeth and Ethel Beach? They are about like you and Marjorie were ten years ago. They with Frank Cartwright sang very sweetly at one session of the Kuliang Convention this last week- "Fairest Lord Jesus, Ruler of all nations". Yesterday I played in the tennis tournament. I did not intend to play this year, but Prof. Metcalf of the University asked me to play with him. He plays about the same as I do. We drew as first opponents the best player on the mountain and his partner- a fairly good player to our surprise we got three games in the first set. The second set they won 6-0.

How I should enjoy looking in on you four girls at Eagles Mere. Mama would too. I remember with keenest pleasure the Sunday Phebe and I spent at Silver Bay in 1921, when Geraldine and Dot were there. Only the other evening I was looking at the photos of the visit. I was talking with the Cushman sisters about your being in Lakeside and they said that was the best place and a wonderfully good place to be in. I judge it is not far behind Silver Bay.

It is very pleasant to think that we have a son and a daughter engaged. The pull is very strong to ask the privelege to go home next year and marry them. I am afraid I could not ask to leave Foochow before June 20. That would bring us home too late for June weddings.

Mr. Nga Geng Guong left Foochow last Monday to go to Oberlin to study. I wrote of him a week ago to Dorothy. You and Marjorie will see him. You may remember him. He sang frequently at Foochow College functions when you were here 1916-1920.



Mr. Nga's 1928 Senior photo from the Oberlin College Hi-O-Hi yearbook.
[*Photo from the Hi-O-Hi yearbook*]

Dr. Gillette went home thru Russia last Spring and his letters written after he had reached Moscow are very interesting. From there we got the idea that conditions are not as bad there as the papers would sometimes have us think.